STEADFAST MEN

Lesson 11 · When Home Never Handed You Off

Transcript · Wes Hart

Good to see you. Come on and sit if you're still standing there. Uh, I watched a man on his way in. He read the page. He looked at the door. Then he sat down real slow, like the chair might file a report. Glad you stayed. If you slipped in late, I'm Wes. Last time we sat with a Father who doesn't walk off. That still stands. Today is the house that raised you. Whether anybody in it ever looked you in the face and told you that you could go. Uh, some of you have a truck that starts, and the day still bends toward their table. You drive over. Uh, you wait on a sentence that has not come. Some of you left hard and called it finished. The fight climbed in beside you anyway. I have been— I have been both of those men. You can't— you can't hand yourself off. If that house never did it, the Father already has, and He keeps men close enough to say it. When you come back, you knock. One sentence puts four marks on a real man. Here they are. A steadfast man stops waiting, picks up the weight, goes first, and works for God's pay, not the room's. Passivity is the hand that will not let go. Reject that. The life is already yours to carry. Responsibility is the honor still owed, and the leaving still yours to do. Courage is the ask, the telling, and the walk up to the door while your heart is still loud. The reward is not your father's apology. If the sentence comes, receive it. If it never comes, you are not unpaid. God's pay. That's the one a steadfast man works for. Uh, look at your own hand. See which side of the door it's on.

Let me say what a handoff actually is. For a long time, men did this on purpose. An older man took a younger one through something hard. He told him what a man is. He laid a man's weight on him. Uh, then he brought him into the company. The boy didn't announce himself. Uh, the men said so, and they meant it. He woke up in their company because they had said his name. Not a feeling he worked up alone. Four pieces. A man. A word. A weight. A welcome. I watched this once, Uh, on a fence line. An older man had his nephew out there all day. Not as a guest. Uh, not as an audience. Near the end he handed him the digger for the last holes. Told him the line had to stay straight. Stood there while the boy did it. Uh, didn't take the tool back when it got crooked. Then he said, you can run a day like this. Come in the morning. You're with us. That was a man. Uh, the uncle, standing there. That was a word. You can run a day. The line stays straight. That was a weight. Those last holes were the boy's to get right. And that was a welcome. Come in the morning. You're with us. Most of us did not get the set. Some of you got the weight and no word. Chores. Bills. Figure it out. Nobody ever called it a man's work. Uh, it was just what needed doing, and you were the one standing there. Some of you got a soft word and nothing to carry. Nice voice. No weight in it. And some of you got silence. A roof, maybe. A ride, sometimes. Uh, no sentence you could find later when you went looking. The want does

not die when the word is missing. You go hunting. And what you find is usually a substitute with a man's shape and none of the pieces.

I have built a few substitutes. They looked solid from the driver's seat. One of them is noise. The night you finally said it all at somebody's table, drove home feeling huge, and called that the night you became a man. Uh, nobody older received you. You just got loud. Uh, loud can pass for a ceremony. It wears off by morning. Another one is miles. You moved. You got your own place. You put your name on a lease and you thought the miles were the moment. Moving your stuff— moving your stuff is real. It is not a handoff. I mean, a boy can change zip codes and stay a boy. Another one is a title. Your name goes on the schedule. People ask you what to do. Uh, that can happen to a boy. Being in charge is not the same as being sent. And the quiet one. The long circle. You stay close. You stay useful. Uh, you keep hoping the house will finally say it. And because, you know, you're not sure you're a man, you won't pick up a man's weight anywhere else. You're waiting to be told it's yours. I did a small version of that circle in a store aisle. I called— I called my dad before I picked. Uh, it was a hose. He lives in another town. He has never seen this hose. Uh, I still wanted him to rule on it. I was waiting on a verdict for a hose. He was kind about it. Uh, confused, mostly. The kindness didn't make me a man. It just showed me whose voice I was still borrowing. None of that had the four pieces. No man giving a true word. Uh, no weight that was actually mine. No welcome into a company. A handoff is received. Men give it. A boy takes it. He does not invent it on the drive home, right? You already know. You've tried.

So hear the Father before you hear anybody else. If you start in another place, it will give way under you. Luke two, verse forty-nine. His parents have been searching the roads. He asks them, why were you searching for me? Didn't you know I had to be in my Father's house? Uh, he wasn't being cruel. His life was already ordered by his Father. And a few verses on, he went down with them and was obedient to them. Center in the right house. Honor still intact. No scene on the way home. Some of you have parents still walking the old roads, looking for a boy they understand. Meanwhile the Father has already put you about His business. If you belong to Christ, that word is not still pending. Galatians four. Because you are his sons, God sent the Spirit of his Son into our hearts, the Spirit who calls out, Abba, Father. So you are no longer a slave, but God's child. And since you are his child, God has made you also an heir. That's a word. Son. Not slave. That's a weight. Heir. Something is actually yours. That's a welcome. Abba. You can come in. When our first child was born, Uh, my dad sent a short note. Congrats. Your mother wants to know when to come. I stood in the hall outside the room and read it twice, looking for a line that wasn't on it. Uh, I wanted somebody to tell me I could do the thing I was already in. You know, the note couldn't say it. I went back in anyway. Uh, the baby didn't know about the note. That weight was already in my arms. If you're— if you're in Christ, the Father has already said son over you. Uh, your dad's sentence is a gift when it comes. It is not the floor.

Then you ask a man to say it where you can hear it. It will feel— it will feel clumsy. Ask anyway. Find a man older than you who is actually living this, and tell him the truth. Nobody ever told me I was a man. Would you tell me what you see? If he'll put a hand on your shoulder, let him. Uh, then take the answer. All of it. If he only flatters you, ask him for the true part. A handoff with no truth in it is just a nice noise. If he names a fault, don't dodge. That may be the first time the word man came with a spine. I practiced my ask in the car. Uh, more than once. The man in the next spot looked over as if I was fussing at him. I was fussing at a steering wheel. Uh, when I finally said it to a man I trusted, he didn't give me a trophy. He said, I see a man who can carry a house, and who still checks home before he trusts his own yes. It stung. I took it. That was closer to a handoff than anything I'd been hunting. Mark the day. Not a mood you might feel later. A day you can point at. The day you asked. The day he said it. Uh, the day you stopped waiting. Put it where your eyes will hit it. A man with no day to point at keeps checking his own pulse to see if he turned into one. And if you're the older man, you are the other half of this. Pick one younger man. Tell him one thing you have watched him do that a man does. A thing he already did. I watched you stay and tell the truth about your own part. That's a man's move. I see a man. How many of you can point to a day when a man said it to your face and you knew he meant you? Let me see them. Yeah. A lot of hands stayed down. So we ask. And we say it.

There was a man in a group I sat in. I'll call him Russ. Uh, he ran a bread route. Up before the street was awake. Good at it. People knew the truck. At home he had a wife and a little girl who was glad when he came through the door. And he still couldn't pick a Sunday without his mother's hand on it. He had a cooler in the trunk. Her containers. He was afraid to bring them back empty, and afraid to throw the food out. Uh, so they stayed back there until they were past saving, and then he felt guilty twice. His wife stopped coming in. She'd sit with the baby, windows cracked, and she didn't pick a fight. One Sunday she said, quiet, she's asleep. I'm taking her home. You can come when you're done asking permission. Russ stood in the driveway with a dish in his hands. He told me he almost got mad. Uh, then he got honest. She was right. Next morning he said it out loud at the table. An older man was there. Uh, I'll call him Hugh. Hugh doesn't waste words. He asked, what day did your dad tell you you were a man? Russ let out one short laugh. He didn't. Hugh nodded. He'd expected that. Then stop waiting on that house to say it. I'll tell you what I see. I see a man who's scared of a quiet phone. I also see a man who can feed his own family at his own table. Both of those are true. Go do the second one. He didn't— he didn't add a sermon. He asked, when. Russ said, this Sunday. He called the day before. Voice unsteady. Mom. We love you. We're eating at our place. Silence. His dad on the other line. Suit yourself. Uh, Russ burned the rolls. His girl thought it was funny. He told me it was the first meal that was finally his. He still goes to see them. He calls first. He doesn't go hunting a sentence. Uh, his dad is still his dad. The visit is a visit now. Not a verdict he's waiting on.

Now look at the door itself. Genesis two, verse twenty-four. That is why a man leaves his father and mother and is united to his wife, and they become one flesh. A man leaves. God said that, not a kid with a bag by the door. And it comes before he is united to his wife. So if you're single, this is already yours. Leaving is not a married man's verb only. Uh, two ways to miss it. Your hand stays on the knob. Or you slam it and call the noise freedom. Both of those men are still in the doorway. They just face different directions. Here's the knob, and it's mine before it's yours. My mother had a real opinion about when the kids should be down. I would agree on the phone. Uh, then I'd walk back in and move our whole evening. Uh, I called it peace. My wife didn't fight me. She looked at me the way you watch a man agree to a house he didn't live in. She wasn't the problem. I hadn't left. If a comment from your father can still empty you out, and you build your choices as a fence against that comment, you are still home. I mean, you just sleep somewhere else. If every big yes still has to be voted on at their table, you moved your furniture. You did not leave. Uh, now the slam. I got sharp with my dad on the phone over something small. I ended it on a short, cold word, and I felt tall for an hour. By supper I had won the argument again. Out loud. To a bowl of green beans. Anger keeps a seat for him. You think you threw him out. He rides into the next room anyway. Uh, your day bends around the man you are not speaking to. What you avoid. What you rehearse. Who you're still proving it to. And your kids are learning a method. They will know how to leave you, because you showed them.

Honor is not pretending. Hear that. You do not have to call a hard man kind. Scripture never asks you to lie about him. Uh, honor is how you treat the place God gave him in your life. The office of father. Not a grade you hand in on his performance. You can— you can use the name Dad without giving a toast that rewrites him. You can make sure he's looked after when he's old, even if he never did that for you. You can pass him the bread and skip the speech. Uh, then, on the drive, you can tell the truth to God, or to a brother, with no sneer in it. I mean, mockery is a slam you can do from another state. Uh, it passes for honesty. It's a boy still swinging. Ephesians six, verse two. Honor your father and mother. That includes a mother who raised you alone. In your house, if you have a wife, she comes first. You can love your mother and still not let her run the evening. Uh, pray his name. Pray hers. Even if the prayer is clumsy. Uh, mine has come out this way. Father, You see him clearer than I do. I don't want to keep carrying this. He hears a prayer that small. Forgiveness sits inside the honor. It is not a speech that says it didn't matter. It mattered. God knows how much. Uh, and it is not the same as trust. You can forgive a man and still refuse to leave your children with him if that house is not safe. Some tables do not get put back. That is not a failure of nerve. Distance can be wisdom. A curse you keep warm in your mouth is still a slam. First Peter two, verse twenty-three. When they hurled their insults at him, he did not retaliate. Instead, he entrusted himself to him who judges justly. Hand Him the debt. Uh, your peace can stop waiting on an apology that may never come. Paying that man back was never your job.

If your father is alive, and it is safe to go near him, there may be a knock you've been postponing. I will not send you into a house that is still dangerous. Some talks only tear open a wound God is already closing. Leave those alone. But a lot of men have had the words ready for years and have never gone to the door. I mean, keep it short. A speech gives him something to swat. Uh, say what you needed and did not get. One sentence. Say one true thanks. A way of getting up early. A roof. Not a performance. Say what you've decided. I'm not gonna build my house on this grudge. I'm done making you pay me. Then stop. Don't charge an apology as the price of the next visit. Uh, what he does with it is his weight. I knew a man. Uh, I'll call him Pete. A holiday went bad and he stopped calling. He told us he was free. Then his own boy, mad about something small, looked at him and said, I don't have to talk to you, and shut a door. Pete heard his own rule in a child's mouth. Uh, he started saying his father's name on the drive. He said the name was gravel in his mouth. He had a box in the garage. Old road maps. His dad's. He'd taken them on the way out, a little prize from the fight. He drove over with the box. Knocked before he could build the speech. These are yours. I took them to prove a point. I'm done proving it. His father held the box. You kept these. Pete said, I don't need them for a fight anymore. The door stayed open long enough to set the box inside. No apology came. Pete didn't chase one. He told me, I gave back what I'd been using as a weapon. That was the knock. Uh, if your father is gone, or you cannot go near him, say it anyway. Say it to God. Say it to a brother. The words still have to leave your chest, even if they cannot reach him.

Let me walk the room for a minute. Uh, young men. The test is whether your yes is yours. You can love them and still decide. Uh, if every yes gets sanded down at their table until it isn't yours, you haven't left. You're borrowing a life. If you're single, don't wait on a wife to make this true. You already have a life to aim. Decide, then tell them, and let the telling carry your love. Don't poll them until the choice is gone. If you're married, you leave. You don't send her in to say the hard thing you were afraid to say. And when a baby shows up, Uh, you'll leave again, in front of people who love hard. Say it in your own voice. This is how our house is gonna run. I love you. I'm not asking you to carry it. If the house got quiet, if the papers are signed, the pull is back toward her table, because she'll make room. Don't hide there from building a life. The Father's word was not torn up when the marriage was. If the house was dangerous, stay away. That can be wisdom. A curse you keep warm is still a slam. Older men. The years did not hand you off. If you still need the word, ask for it. A younger man is in reach. You are the one who starts. A grudge with years on it is not wisdom. If your son slammed, or he drifted, be the one who goes toward him. Make the call that doesn't get answered. If you failed him, say it once. If he knocks, there's a place for him. And if the work is going well, a title— a title is not a departure. You can be the man they call when it breaks and still be a boy at that table. How many of you are still getting a real decision cleared by a house you don't live in? Go ahead. Be honest. Yeah. Uh, that one's for the steady-looking men. I was in it with the hose. You know what to do with it now.

Let me bring this down to the table. Nobody hands himself off. If you are his, the Father already handed you off. What I hope— what I hope you walk out with is which side of the door you've been on, and one move with a day on it. Uh, your workbook is where this gets particular. So get the questions in your ear. Who handed you off, and when? Or will you say the bare line. Nobody ever told me I was a man. Did you slam, or did you keep orbiting? If the leaving is the sharper edge, say knob or slam, and name what it has cost. Your wife, if you have one. Your kids. Your own days. If you're the younger man, which older man will you ask whether he sees a man in you? And will you take whatever he says? If you're the older man, which younger man will you tell, and what have you watched him do that a man does? On the leaving. What is one decision you will make without clearing it first, and then tell them, with love in it? Or will you pray for your father by name, day by day, and if he is alive and it's safe, what day will you go knock? Tell a brother all of it. Whether you were handed off. The date you are going to write inside your Bible. Which side of the door you have been standing on. And if the knock is coming, when. If you skip the brother, the day stays imaginary. Carry this. A man, a word, a weight, and a welcome. Nobody hands himself off. The Father already handed you off, and He keeps men ready to say it out loud. Honor the office. Tell the truth about the man. Hand the debt to God. And knock when you come home. The marks still stand. A steadfast man stops waiting, picks up the weight, goes first, and works for God's pay, not the room's. Tables are yours. Work this part of the workbook together. I'm not going far.